275,000 Connections linked to spam activities disconnected by service providers in 2024

41% of people aged 65 and above don't answer unknown calls globally, highlighting psychological impact of spam

Sources: Airtel, TRAI, DoT



"We are building firewalls at various levels to stay ahead"

Union communications minister Jyotiraditya Scindia speaks to INDIA TODAY's Avishek G. Dastidar about the growing menace of spam calls and messages, and the government's action plan to combat it

On the existence of spam

With the advent of technology, every new paradigm shift brings with it a tremendous amount of dividends. But it also brings with it...elements that are mischievous and make it a bit of a nuisance. That is the case with every technological curve in human history, and so is the case with telecom technology. In the recent past, things have escalated tremendously.

On the role of telecom operators and telemarketers

We've mandated that telecom service providers appoint chief telecom security officers in their organisations. Security incidents must be reported within six hours, and [service] providers must comply with telecom equipment regulations, including IMEI number verification. We've made it clear...that unless a subscriber opts in, they cannot be contacted. We've blacklisted 1,100 entities and disconnected 18.5 lakh mobile numbers involved in unsolicited commercial communications.

On the government's moves against spam and fraud calls

Our AI-based tool ASTRA leverages facial recognition for SIM subscriber verification. We've found instances where one person's photo was used for up to 800 SIM cards. Through ASTRA, we analysed 14 crore mobile connections and disconnected 78 lakh fraudulent connections. Additionally, we...suspended 70,000 points of sale involved in these practices. Using a calling line identification system, we've blocked 89 per cent of all spoofed calls, with a peak of 1.35 crore calls blocked in 24 hours.

On the way forward

We are building firewalls at various levels to stay ahead. While technology will always bring challenges, our commitment is to ensure that customers are protected and not harassed or defrauded. ■

A Work in Progress

India's battle against spam is not new. The Do Not Disturb (DND) registry, launched in 2007, aimed to let users block telemarketing calls and messages. Except that telemarketers soon found ways to circumvent the system. "The problem of spams needed to be addressed by distinguishing spam from acceptable commercial communication at the originating end. A system for the same and regulatory regime was needed," says TRAI chairman Anil Kumar Lahoti, explaining how India's response to spams evolved over time. "The DLT [blockchain technology] makes that possible."

In India, TRAI has worked with telcos to enforce strict rules, such as the use of 140-prefixed numbers for promotional calls and mandatory whitelisting of URLs and APKs in SMS messages. Yet, the spam continues. Officials say people ignore '140' numbers fearing they are spams. The PEs have been asked to complete the "chain" connecting all their partner business entities who send messages and calls on their behalf. This is because big telemarketing companies serving PEs may subcontract their jobs to smaller players who might not be registered. So the system couldn't hold anyone accountable. Some 14,000 PEs have so far declared 21,000 chains of telemarketers. The loopholes are being plugged.

For users like Nabamita, the results are mixed. Government and private efforts have reduced some spam, but enforcement gaps persist. Experts argue that while Airtel's AI and TRAI's blockchain system are significant steps, they must be supplemented with stricter penalties and consumer awareness campaigns. But that may still be inadequate. As Scindia says, spams are the unavoidable side-effects of the tech we use. "You get a lot of dividends with technology but there are also people who try to be mischievous. You've got to just block them."

For millions of Indians, this is a fight for privacy, security and trust. Every time headway is made, there is a fresh fusillade of spam. And the battle gets tougher. ■